



If you find toward the end of pregnancy that you have a sudden **burst of energy** to scrub the house thoroughly from top to bottom, put this down to a **primal nesting instinct** thought to stem from a need to **prepare for** and **protect** your new arrival.

Tidy your home

A well-documented phenomenon, the desire to clean, organize, and “nest” can take hold of many an expectant mother. It’s fine to deal with the house now; cleaning thoroughly will be one less thing to worry about when your baby arrives, and should make your environment more relaxing and enjoyable. Use eco-friendly cleaning products where you can so you don’t inhale hazardous fumes. You may also want to store clothes you won’t wear until the next season to create more room in your closet, or file paperwork, for example. However, be sensible and don’t overdo it. And if you don’t get everything organized just so, try not to worry.



Get cooking

Spend some time rustling up a few nutritious home-cooked meals for the freezer to enjoy in the weeks after the birth. First-time parents are often surprised by just how much time a new baby takes up; you may be too exhausted to spend time cooking. This will reduce the temptation to resort to unhealthy convenience foods, and help to ensure you eat a nutritious diet while breast-feeding. Label and date items so you can keep track of what needs to be eaten when. Take a look in your freezer and pantry too, and stock up on supplies. Consider setting up an online food shopping account if you don’t have one already.



A QUICK CHECKLIST

Make your own checklist to refer to and check off the tasks as they are done. You might want to include some of the following:



CLOTHES AND EQUIPMENT

- » Look through everything you have bought and check that it is all there.
- » Wash new clothes, burp cloths, and bed linen using nonbiological detergent.
- » Pack some baby clothes in your hospital bag along with your own supplies.
- » Make sure you know how the bottle sanitizing unit works.
- » Test out the stroller.
- » Install the car seat.



GOING TO THE HOSPITAL

- » Make sure you are familiar with the route.
- » Check that you have the money for parking, if needed.
- » Ask if you need a pass when you arrive.
- » Check that your hospital bag is packed and ready to go.
- » Make sure you have contact details of friends and family.



HOME LIFE

- » Make a list of chores that will need to be done.
- » Discuss with your partner how to split tasks when your baby has arrived.
- » If you have other children, make a plan for what will happen to them when you go to the hospital.
- » Stock the freezer and pantry with nutritious food.
- » Buy files to store bills and mail that require a response.
- » Get up to date on bills.